The Salt Playa (Dry Basin)

1. Start at Row I, Column D (marked with 3 and [C]).
2. Advance one row per step, traveling from Row I down to Row VII.
3. Move only to an adjacent cell in the row below (straight down or diagonal).
4. Cells marked with [X] are impassable sinkholes. Never step on them.
5. The number in each step must be exactly 1 higher or 1 lower (+1 or −1).
6. The letters along your 7-step path reveal the passage keyword.

	COL A	COL B	COL C	COL D	COL E	COL F	COL G
ROW I	1 [M]	5 [X]	6 [B]	3 [C]	1 [Q]	6 [Z]	2 [V]
ROW II	4 [G]	2 [E]	X	6 [K]	4 [R]	1 [J]	5 [U]
ROW III	3 [F]	X	2 [I]	5 [Y]	X	2 [P]	6 [D]
ROW IV	5 [O]	1 [A]	4 [S]	2 [W]	X	5 [B]	3 [T]
ROW V	2 [L]	X	3 [T]	6 [H]	1 [N]	X	6 [M]
ROW VI	6 [K]	5 [N]	X	2 [A]	5 [R]	3 [E]	1 [S]
ROW VII	3 [P]	1 [Z]	4 [O]	1 [L]	X	6 [C]	2 [Y]

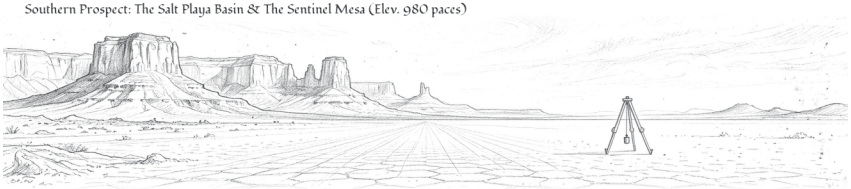
The 7 Stepping Stones Waypoint Log (North to South Transit):

ROW I	ROW II	ROW III	ROW IV	ROW V	ROW VI	ROW VII
[___]	[___]	[___]	[___]	[___]	[___]	[___]

Passage Keyword: [___] [___] [___] [___] [___] [___] [___]

Transmit the 7-letter keyword to the Web Navigator Console to unlock the South Shore.

Southern Prospect: The Salt Playa Basin & The Sentinel Mesa (Elev. 980 paces)

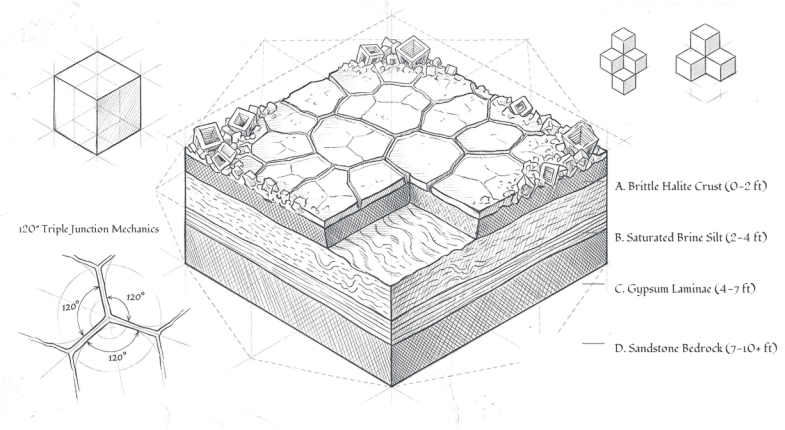


Study on the Dry Salt Playa

I. Mechanical Principles of Crust Buckling & Desiccation

As solar heat bakes the playa, capillary suction pulls saturated brine up through fissures.
Crystallizing salt expands by volume, forcing polygon plate edges to buckle into sharp ridges.
Where subterranean waters dissolve the silt from beneath, treacherous sinkholes form unseen.
The traveler must test every slab before bearing full weight, as dry crusts conceal deep brine.

Fig. I - Morphological Cutaway of the Salt Playa & Halite Crystallography



II. The Architect's Note (Field Codex Entry):

«The water that flows carries the memory of the heights; but the salt that remains
is the crystal skeleton of the earth, holding the light long after the storm has turned to dust.
Let the seeker who traverses the playa walk with measured footsteps,
for weight without balance yields perpetually to the deep beneath.»

